

Music On The Move

Q I am planning to buy a new cell phone soon. I have my sights set on the new Nokia 3250 music phone. I need a recommendation: should I opt for this phone? Are there better music phones around? My budget is about what the Nokia 3250 retails for.

Vijay

 The keypad layout and interface of the 3250 is typical of Nokia—simple and intuitive. There isn't much difference between this phone and the older 3230 phone. You get a 512 MB Micro SD card to store your music, and a 3.2 mm stereo jack—good, because you can connect any headphone set. Another phone you should check out before you choose the Nokia 3250 is the Sony Ericsson W810i. Since both these are touted as music phones, and you plan to use your phone primarily as a music player, I suggest you get a good feel for both before buying. Go to a shop and spend some time checking out the keypad and the music buttons.

A Good Old CRT

Q I want to buy a good 19-inch CRT monitor. What brand and model should I opt for? Please give me two options!

Arindam

 There are hardly any choices in the CRT market: Samsung, LG, and Philips are the predominant brands. The choice is further limited in the 19-inch category. I'd recommend a Samsung, not because they are exceptional, but because they seem a little more serious about the CRT business. (Most traditional CRT manufacturers are moving to TFT panels, and so are focusing less on CRTs.) Samsung has a good CRT line. There are two Samsung models I would recommend—the SyncMaster 997DF and 957MB.

Cam Confusion

Q I am planning to buy a digital camera and my budget is Rs 18,000 to 20,000. I have no particular model in mind.

S V Subba Rao

 Your budget is good enough to get a really good digicam. I'm considering street prices and not the official prices—which are atrocious. Check out the Panasonic DMC-FZ7: this is a pseudo-SLR-styled digital camera, has 12x optical zoom, Leica lenses, and image stabilisation. The FZ7 will set you back by around Rs 20,000. The only problem with the FZ7 is its size, and if you're looking for a compact point-and-shoot camera, opt for Canon's A700 or Sony's W50 and W70 series. These will cost Rs 15,000 or so.

On A Tight Speaker Budget

Q I am an avid gamer and am looking for a speaker set. I have space constraints, so I've decided to settle for a 2.1 set. Can you suggest a good set that costs about Rs 2,500? Also, I listen to heavy metal or rock most of the time, so clarity is of utmost importance.

Akshay



Your budget is too low for me to suggest a good 2.1 speaker set. The Zebronics SW-8000 will fit your budget, and it performs well enough for the price tag.

Have Money, Will Spend...

Q I want to buy a home theatre system along with a large screen TV. As far as large screens are concerned, I don't understand the difference between LCD and DLP: could you please elaborate on these? I have set aside Rs 50,000 for the audio part and Rs 3 to 4 lakhs for the video devices.

Samrat Mazumdar



Wow, will you adopt me? Four lakhs is more than enough to build a fantastic home theatre system. There are two parts to a home theatre; Video and Audio. The proper combinations of both makes the theatre experience richer. As far as video goes, bigger screens naturally mean a better experience. There are two ways to bigger screens—first, via multimedia projectors, and second, by using large screen LCDs or plasma TVs.

You get two types or projectors based on the technology they use—LCD and DLP. Most multimedia projectors today are based on DLP technology, and an entry-level device will set you back Rs 2 to 3 lakhs. Frankly speaking, nothing compares to the level of experience a projector provides; however, your living room should be long enough for the projector to project a large-format image. You will also need a good projector screen. On the other hand, if you have space constraints, you should consider opting for a large screen LCD; plasma TVs are out of vogue.

If you want to buy a new large screen LCD, make sure it supports HDMI (High Definition Multimedia Interface). This is a new interface capable of transmitting uncompressed, high-definition video and audio content over a single cable, thus reducing cable clutter when connecting home theatre systems.

On the audio front, you will have to invest in a good "receiver," probably from brands such as Denon, NAD, and others, and a 5.1 speaker set from brands such as Wharfedale, PSB, and Sonodyne. Also, to play DVDs, you will require a good DVD player; brands available are Denon, Marantz, and some others. A good receiver will set you back by Rs 40,000; the 5.1 speaker set will cost you a lakh, and the DVD player another Rs 25,000. Whoops, I think I just overshot even your generous budget!

I Want A Nano!

Q I want to buy a Digital Audio player (DAP). I have a budget of around Rs 15,000; will I be able to buy an iPod Nano or Samsung YP-T1?

Mayank Rajawat



For Rs 15,000, you can easily get your hands on an iPod Nano. I'm not sure about the YP-T1 though. If you want to look at the grey market, you can easily get a 30 GB iPod Video for the same price. If I were in your position, I would have chanced the grey market. ■



Ask Away!

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